

Magic and the fantasy novel

Although the first modern fantasy novels were written in the 19th century, the genre reached maturity in the mid-20th century with the publication of what are now some of its best-known works—all of which have magic at their hearts. The most celebrated of these is J.R.R. Tolkien's *The Lord of The Rings*. Like Tolkien's earlier book, *The Hobbit*, it conjures a world of people and elves, dwarves and hobbits, wizards and wraiths.

Also set in a magical place, C.S. Lewis's seven-volume series *The Chronicles of Narnia* explores magical dangers and wonders in Narnia, a land of fauns and a wicked White Witch, entered through a magical wardrobe. Unlike Tolkien's works, however, the Narnia titles are set only partly in this fantasy world—a characteristic they share with J.K. Rowling's renowned *Harry Potter* series. C.S. Lewis chose Pauline Baynes, who had illustrated some of Tolkien's books, to provide the drawings for the whole series.

The otherworldly settings, enchantments, and mythical beasts common to fantasy novels can often be traced back to earlier myths, legends, or fairy tales. For instance, T.H. White's *The Once and Future King*, a set of four books published together in 1958, is based on the myth of King Arthur and his court, Camelot. This vivid legend of magic, love, betrayal, and downfall was first written down during the medieval period (see p.110).

“Do not cite the Deep Magic to me, Witch. I was there when it was written.”

C.S. LEWIS, *THE LION, THE WITCH AND THE WARDROBE*, 1950

